

We Burn Undead

In the Dragon Isles there is no priest who lifts a holy symbol and sends the skeletons scattering. You don't turn undead. You burn undead. The dead are dry: old bone, grave-linen, tomb-dust, the leathered husk of a thing that stopped drinking centuries ago. Nothing takes a torch more gladly. Light the barrow, and stand back.

"We burn undead." — the old barrow wisdom, and more oil than sense.

At the Battle of the Thousandfold Curses the Eldar had the Kha'din trapped in the Wintercrowns, and were losing. Reshuk, god of the dead, offered a bargain: he would send his children to win the war, if the living promised to feed them. The Eldar agreed. The fallen on the field rose not alive, but Deurg'Gul, the Undying Ones — what lesser tongues call the Fallen. By dawn they had turned their blades on kin. The Undying Lands became Sepulchre: Dearg-dul country, Tir'Na'Deurg'Gul, the Sea of Bones. Some say the Kha'din's own curses raised the dead, and Reshuk only turned them. Every later thrall, barrow-wight, Zuhl, and vampire lord comes of that bargain.

Hunger, age, and disease leave them alone. Spears, arrows, even a sword thrust into the gaps of plate — veterans say none of it told. Magicks aimed at the living fail: *illusion, charm, sleep, fear, hold*. The joys of life are shut besides. They cannot bear sunlight, cannot cross running water, cannot enter a house uninvited, cannot take bread nor ale nor salt. Beasts see them true, and will not bear them.

The old tales wander, but the oldest say fyre maketh et goote. Show them fire and the husks that fear it recoil — a torch in the barrow, a brand in the press, holy oil on the step. Drive them from the light. Torch, oil, naphtha, a thrown pot, holy water, holy oil. Willful undead laugh at a bare flame. Bring more oil than you think you need.

They remember what they were. Heart turns them because you call up what they miss. The fyre brand is what they cannot endure.

Anyone they slew may look only dead — a friend, a hireling, a Boss's sworn hand. Carry them home for a clean burial and by Midnight they may rise as that thing's spawn. Put them on the pyre with the bones and they rest. Same choice when an undead Wound opens. When they wound you they do more than cut. The hunger that raised the Deurg'Gul is in the cut. As Midnight nears it grips, chills, and writhes.

"They hunt the living. They can smell you. Hide all you like — they know you're there."

"Show them fire. A torch'll turn the husks — they run from the light. That's as close as you'll get to turning. The willful ones laugh at a torch. Those you burn. Bring more oil."

"What they take off you, you don't sleep back. A potion, a working — or you burn it out, and the fyre costs you."

"Boys, hold Herrick down and bring the fyre, we need to purge him."

"A wound from the dead is worse. It worsens. Come Midnight the cut writhes. Hold him down and bring the fyre. He lives, he's clean. He dies of the burn, he rests. You leave it, come morning he's gone — or he's one of them."

"Burn the bones. Burn whoever they killed. You leave a body, it gets up."

"Anyone they slay gets up. That's the whole of it."

Facing the Fallen

- Undead have unnatural senses that can find the living.
- Undead fear naught but fire, and can be driven back by fire.
- Undead cannot cross running water (unless carried).
- Undead do not die unless purged in fire or holy water (or holy oil, holy fyre, etc).
- Anyone slain by undead rises as undead unless you purge or bless their remains (e.g. with holy water).

Touch of the Fallen

Damage inflicted by undead does not come back with normal rest. For example, 3 HP lost will not return when resting, and a 3-point Wound will not heal with sleep. The only options are magical healing, purifying with holy water, or purging it with fire.

You can purify damage from undead with holy water. Each flask of holy water can purify 1d6 HP of damage.

You can purge damage from undead with fire. This expends one incendiary, and you gain a Wound equal to the total hit points of damage you are purging. For example, 5 HP lost to undead, purged creates a 5-point burn Wound.

At midnight, any Wound inflicted by undead worsens by 1d6 plus the undead HD (skeleton 1d6+1, zombie 1d6+2, wight 1d6+3, etc.). Immediately make a Survival Check.